Where You Are: The First Step in Dad's Care and the Eight That Follow

All nine steps of the Family Care Roadmap, and what the first one gives you.

The week Dad started needing help, a dozen questions arrived together: where he'll be, who will help, what happens after that. They can be taken one at a time. They come in an order, and the first is the plainest one: what is the situation right now?

This page lays out all nine steps, marks the one you're on, and says who is involved in what follows.

Phase 1 · Care Assessment

Understand the person, the family, and the situation.

1 **Discover** Current Situation → Concerns & Challenges → Goals & Priorities
You finish with: Family Discovery Summary

You are here. This is step one, and you're on its first topic: the current situation. You finish the topic with one clear page: what happened, how Dad's days are arranged now, who is involved and what each person does, the decisions coming up, and what is still unknown, with a family contact named.

2 **Assess** Health & Function → Safety & Support → Lifestyle & Preferences
You finish with: Personal Care Assessment Summary

3 **Define Needs** Needs & Risks → Care Requirements → Priorities & Recommendations
You finish with: Care Needs Profile and Immediate Action Roadmap

Phase 2 · Care Planning

Determine what good care should look like and prepare to put it in place.

4 **Explore Options** Care Setting → Provider/Facility Fit → Selection & Decision
You finish with: Care Options Comparison and Decision Record

5 **Build the Plan** Health & Personal Care → Daily Life & Quality of Life → Monitoring & Response
You finish with: Personal Care Proposal, Good Day Plan, and Monitoring Plan

6 **Prepare the Transition** Preparation → Move & Admission → Continuity of Care
You finish with: Transition Preparation Pack and Confirmed Handoff Log

Phase 3 · Care Management

Coordinate the plan, review what happens, and prepare the family to take the lead.

7 **Coordinate** People & Responsibilities → Communication & Handoffs → Care-Plan Alignment
You finish with: Care Team Plan and Care-Plan Alignment Record

8 **Monitor** Monitor → Identify & Escalate → Review & Adjust
You finish with: Care Review Dashboard and Concern/Change Logs

9 **Hand Off** Educate → Empower → Support

You finish with: Family Care Management Playbook and Handoff/Support Plan

What this step produces

A current, written picture of Dad's situation that the whole family can read. Your part is done when three things are in hand: a current summary, a named family contact, and a list of the immediate decisions with the unknowns marked instead of guessed. It organizes what the family knows. It doesn't assess Dad.

It can be short. AARP's planning guide says of a family's caregiving plan that it helps everyone get on the same page, and that it doesn't have to be extensive or fancy. The same goes for this first page. [1]

What happens next

Two more topics finish the Discover step: the concerns and challenges in front of the family, and its goals and priorities. The page you write now is where both begin. After Discover comes Assess, which looks at health and function, safety and support, and lifestyle and preferences.

The page isn't written once and filed. The Family Caregiver Alliance says a family meeting is not a one-time event, and that families should meet again when the caregiving situation changes. Expect to update this page the same way. [2]

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: gathering the notes, writing the page, naming a contact and a backup.
- Dad: his own account of what happened and of what he wants, wherever he is able to give it.
- His care team (doctor, nurse, discharge planner or social worker): the clinical questions, and the dates and decisions that come from their side.
- A care professional: where a family works with your care consultant, a family interview follows the care interview. It goes over the current care arrangement, what a typical day looks like, and who is doing what, including whether one person is carrying most of the work.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available to help, or how things turn out for Dad. The nine steps are an order, not a schedule.

Ready for the next step?

You know where you're starting, what this step produces and what follows it. The care interview is the way through this first step: it asks about Dad's living arrangement, his typical day and each area of daily life in order, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Family Care Roadmap's own. The remarks that a plan gets everyone on the same page, and that families meet again when the situation changes, come from AARP and the Family Caregiver Alliance.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting